

don't know how to navigate it.

>

> If you put structure around this, and you document it, you eliminate the guilt and the fear of missing out. · Emna G., founder and CEO at Veamyly

It's important for leadership to set the tone, but it's even more important to document what will define your culture. Each time a scenario arises where there is no clearly defined answer, look to your company values to determine the answer, and then document.

Documentation is a shared benefit, and is something that should be embraced by all members of the organization. While it may feel inefficient to document nuances related to culture, creating good habits around this will ensure that culture is as strong in the future as it was in a company's infancy.

Close the office

Where feasible, consider closing the office and operating as a 100% remote company. This eliminates the possibility of any remote employee being seen, intentionally or unintentionally, as deprioritized within the organization.

If this is not feasible, and your company operates elsewhere on the spectrum of remote, ensure that your culture reinforces a remote-first way of doing business. It takes a concerted effort to transcribe hallway conversations into one's handbook or Slack channels, but ensuring that each employee is seen as a remote employee is the only way to ensure equal access to information.

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

Contribute your lessons

Creating and evolving company culture is something that all remote organizations must tackle. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Building and reinforcing a sustainable culture

Complete all knowledge assessments in the Remote Work Foundation certification to receive the Remote Foundations Badge in GitLab Learn. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

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[Contribute to this page](#)

At GitLab, we recognize that the whole idea of all-remote organizations is still quite new, and can only be successful with active participation from the whole community. Here's how you can participate:

- Propose or suggest any change to this site by a merge request.
- Create an issue if you have any questions or if you see an inconsistency.
- Help spread the word about all-remote organizations by sharing it on social media, using the `allremote` hashtag.

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Despite all of its advantages, all-remote work isn't for everyone. It can have disadvantages for potential employees depending on their lifestyle and work preferences, as well as the organization. In the spirit of transparency, we'll also highlight counterpoints and solutions to these challenges.

{{< youtube "CwOLAKSdlfs" >}}

In the video above, GitLab Director of Technical Evangelism Priyanka Sharma discusses pros and cons of remote working with a panel of experts from TFIR, Arm and ISG Research.

The difference between all-remote and remote-first

All-remote is a work arrangement in which employees do not commute to a central place of work because there are no company-owned offices.

Remote-first typically means there is a physical workplace of some kind available to employees who need or prefer a traditional office space outside of the home. However, these spaces are not always company-owned, they could be a shared workspace, coffee shop, or public library.

Remote-first organizations optimize their company for remote by creating documentation, policies, and workflows that assume 100% of the organization is remote.

These companies work to ensure that offices are simply venues to work remotely from, and are not the epicenter of power or culture.

Remote work challenges and solutions for employees

Challenge: Onboarding

Onboarding can be difficult when you're remote, because it involves more self-learning and you're not physically with your new coworkers and fellow new hires.

Solution

Learn more about how GitLab onboards its all-remote team members.

Challenge: Loneliness

The first month in a remote role can feel lonely, especially if you're transitioning from a traditional office setting.

Solutions

- To prevent loneliness, all-remote companies should consider an intentional structure to informal communications.
- Scheduling coffee chats, social calls, and incentivizing in-person visits between team members are several of the ways in which GitLab accomplishes this.

Challenge: Communication breakdown

Remote settings can cause a breakdown in communication skills if organizations aren't deliberate about creating ways for their people to stay connected.

Solutions

- All-remote companies should default to asynchronous communication to combat feelings of being left out of important discussions.
- We welcome all-remote companies to glean from GitLab's approach to meetings, as well as our scheduled AMAs, group conversations, and Key Reviews that are open to all.

Challenge: Work/life balance

Some may find it difficult to work in the same setting as they live and sleep, because a dedicated workspace helps to switch the context from their home life to work.

Solutions

- All-remote companies should not assume that team members will work from their home 100% of the time. Organizations can consider reimbursing coworking space usage and creating an atmosphere where team members are encouraged to construct a workspace that is ideal for their comfort and productivity.
- GitLab team members have shared their own solutions in a number of blog posts, including a series on working at home with kids and utilizing an RV as a traveling office.

Challenge: Different time zones

Team members in different time zones may have to compromise on meeting times.

Solutions

- All-remote companies should consider meetings as a last resort, instead relying on asynchronous collaboration tools like Google Docs and GitLab Issues to facilitate meaningful dialog without time zone concerns.
- To prevent pent-up frustration over working odd hours to facilitate a global call, all-remote companies should consider treating each team member as a manager of one. This goes beyond the basic definition of flexibility by empowering team members to structure each day according to

the needs at hand. For example, spending more time with family earlier in the day to compensate for a late-night work call.

Challenge: Separating work from personal life

It can be hard to separate your personal and work life. It's important to encourage boundaries and make sure you don't continue to work during your family time.

Solutions

- Preventing a culture of burnout starts at the top. In all-remote companies, it's important to reinforce this from the interview process, to onboarding, to regular 1:1s.
- All-remote companies should consider implementing a Results value, where impact (as opposed to activity) are measured. Fundamentally, this requires organizational trust · believing that colleagues will do the right thing rather than implementing rigid rules.
- At GitLab, we encourage team members to communicate with their manager when they recognize burnout, and to be mindful of the last time a team member took time off from work.

Challenge: Time management

Remote work requires you to manage your own time and be self-motivated, disciplined, and organized.

Solutions

- All-remote companies tend to attract those who place a high degree of value on autonomy. To some degree, companies who are hiring can expect applicants to opt-in to this way of working.
- Screening employees for these attributes is fairly easy during the interview process. Even if a prospective team member has yet to work in a remote setting, asking for examples of their mindset and performance while working from home, an event, or while traveling can provide valuable insight.
- While each team member is different, you can get a glimpse of what it's like to operate in an all-remote setting through this GitLab blog post, entitled A day in the life of the "average" remote worker.

Remote work challenges and solutions for organizations

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In the video above, GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij discusses some of the organizational challenges involved in building and sustaining an all-remote company.

Challenge: Non-traditional setup

Because it's non-traditional, all-remote work sometimes concerns investors, partners, and

customers.

Solutions

- All-remote companies are welcome to glean from GitLab's template for keeping investors in the loop.
- For those in the early stages of fundraising for an all-remote company, here are 30 tips from GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij.
- For even more on this topic, listen to Sid unpack why venture firms struggle to fund all-remote startups with Maren Kate, host of the Remote AF podcast (link no longer available).

> "In the beginning they assess your team, then they assess your product, and then they assess your financials. When it comes to the team, [investors are] super skeptical they will be able to create something with all-remote. Then when it's about the product they say, 'Yes, maybe, but what about scaling?' And then when it's about the financials you can let the numbers speak for themselves so it's less of a concern. · GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij

Challenge: Compliance

Differences in currency as well as tax, immigration, and labor laws around the world can create compliance challenges for the organization.

Solution

- While each organization is unique, we welcome other all-remote companies to learn from GitLab's ever-evolving approach to hiring and remaining compliant across the globe.

Challenge: Company culture

You have to be more intentional about cultivating, sustaining, and documenting your company culture.

Solutions

- While this is an obstacle for all-remote companies, colocated organizations should be deliberate about documenting their culture as well.
- All-remote organizations should document everything, including values, and ensure that they are easily accessible to all.
- GitLab demonstrates this with its Handbook, a living document that is continually iterated on by team members. We encourage all-remote organizations to glean from this and develop their own handbook.

Remote work challenges and solutions for teams

Despite its many advantages, all-remote work can present new challenges for teams.

Challenge: Isolation

A remote role can feel lonely, especially if you're transitioning from a traditional office setting.

Solutions

- Build an intentional structure for informal communication to help combat loneliness.
- Schedule regular coffee chats, social calls, and incentivize in-person visits between team members to encourage team building and prevent isolation.

Challenge: Communication

If teams aren't intentional about creating ways for their people to stay connected, remote settings can cause communication breakdowns.

Solutions

- Asynchronous communication invites everyone to be a part of important discussions.
- We welcome all-remote companies to glean from GitLab's approach to meetings, as well as our scheduled AMAs, group conversations, and Key Reviews that are open to all.

Challenge: Boundaries

It's not easy to separate work and personal life when working remote. It's important to model and encourage boundaries.

Solutions

- Preventing a culture of burnout starts at the top. In all-remote companies, it's important to reinforce this from the interview process, to onboarding, to regular 1:1s.
- Focus on impact (as opposed to activity).
- At GitLab, we encourage team members to communicate with their manager when they recognize burnout, and to be mindful of the last time a team member took time off from work.
- Remote work requires you to manage your own time and be self-motivated, disciplined, and organized.

Is working remotely effective?

An all-remote job will best suit self-motivated people. Some of the top optimizers of remote work are:

- Reduced interruption stress and increased productivity.
- Remote makes it easier to communicate with difficult colleagues remotely, reducing distractions from interpersonal drama or office politics.
- Flexibility to choose your working hours based on when you're most productive.

Tips for independent remote working

Whether you're new to working remotely or have done it before, you can explore the detailed version of our 5 tips for successful remote working:

1. Create a dedicated workspace (focus)
1. Separate work from life (avoid burnout)
1. Keep engaging with people (avoid loneliness)

1. Respect routine, but experiment with change (balance)
1. Be flexible and roll with the changes (iteration)

When a remote team will save your business

From the cost savings on office space to more flexibility in employees' daily lives, all-remote work offers a number of advantages to organizations and their people.

{{< youtube "embed/GKMUs7WXm-E" >}}

> "Remote is not a challenge to overcome. It's a clear business advantage." -Victor, Product Manager, GitLab

You can view our complete guide to the benefits of all-remote here.

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As an all-remote company that defaults to asynchronous communication, GitLab relies heavily on textual communication. This can feel unusual or even uncomfortable for those who come from a colocated environment, where in-person meetings and vocalized communiques are the norm. Embracing text communication and learning to use it effectively requires a mental shift. Mastering this should be seen as a long-term project, though there are tips to breaking down barriers and experiencing benefits.

Be sure to read GitLab's guidelines to effective and responsible communication to understand the foundational elements on which this all-remote guide is built.

Tips for better writing

Writing is a skill which can be learned. Great writing involves mastering proven principles and understanding how narratives influence thoughts and actions. Below, we've documented a series of principles which are commonly linked to writing procedures at Amazon (source: Alex Garcia's X (Twitter) thread), but are useful approaches for anyone communicating in a professional setting.

1. Use short sentences. Ideally, sentences should have fewer than 15 words. This improves clarity. The Hemingway Editor helps achieve this.
1. Cut common phrases. Example: replace "due to the fact" with "because."
1. Replace adjectives with data. Hard figures trump descriptors like "most" or "the majority."
1. Eliminate ambiguous words. Actively avoid words which weaken your point (Example: "nearly" instead of an exact percentage)
1. Use the "So What?" test. Before sending a communique, re-read and ask "So, what?" Does your content provide value? Will your audience understand? Are you sharing enough context?
1. Avoid adverbs. If you spot an adverb, remove it. Example: replace "increased massively" with "added 300 new subscribers."
1. Be objective. Objectivity injects confidence. Example: replace "I think this change is

working" with "our new approach led to a 5% increase."

1. Cut acronyms and jargon. Aim to explain to a child. Example: do not assume that someone understands what MR means. Instead, write out "merge request."

1. Use Subject-Verb-Object sentences. Follow this path when constructing sentences: Who/what are you writing about? · What did they do? · What was acted on?

Why text communication is important for successful remote working

{{< youtube "trYrbPYOfc" >}}

The topics covered on this page were discussed in a GitLab Live Learning session, which was recorded and uploaded to GitLab Unfiltered, and is embedded above.

In an all-remote organization with team members spread across an array of time zones, communicating through text is ideal. Not only is it inclusive and considerate, but a bias towards communicating through text creates a company that documents everything.

Documentation is an essential competitive advantage. Companies which rely on vocalizing end up repeating themselves over and over in meetings, creating an inefficient environment with tremendous opportunity for knowledge leaks. While communicating and documenting through text may feel like a burden in the moment, it prevents a toxic cycle of meetings and touch points which serve only to "bring people up to speed."

Tim Casasola of Sanctuary Computer asserts that "great writing makes remote work better. It saves time, reduces meetings, removes extrovert bias, and invites other perspectives."

Communicating answers to problems via text makes documentation easier. Rather than transcribing one's voice, one must simply copy and paste in a structured format within a company's handbook. It's vital to understand that nurturing this habit serves more than the person receiving the answer. It is, in essence, paying it forward. Documenting solutions makes a more efficient future for every new hire who joins and asks the same question, not to mention existing team members who join a project or conversation midstream and need to understand what steps have been taken thus far (and why).

Below are several additional reasons to master the art of textual communication in a business.

1. Allows for team members to work asynchronously
1. Information is available to all at the same time / immediate
1. Allows for deliberate thought and processing time
1. Inherently inclusive (works with screen readers and translation tools)
1. Easily queried via keyboard or script
1. Can be structured and formatted to showcase a train of thought

Understanding low-context communication

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<p>At GitLab, we communicate assuming others have low context. We provide as much context as possible to avoid confusion.</p>
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1. The goal of low context is to be considerate of the people or audience you're speaking to. It's important to recognize that what you write · either internally or externally · may be read in the future, or by someone who is coming into the conversation at a time after the initial thread began

1. This is one of the more challenging elements to master, particularly for those coming from careers in colocated spaces. In colocated environments, high context communication is the default. High context is less direct with an emphasis on human relations, and it's more sensitive to non-verbals and the feelings of others.

1. Getting oneself in a low context frame of mind can be useful. Start by assuming that recipients of your communication do not know anything about the topic at hand, and wish to learn as much as possible in as little time as possible.

1. It's easy to imply your experiences with text communication, but remember that not everyone has similar life experiences to relate to, hence the need to be precise.

1. By being specific, you're forcing yourself to think through what you're saying. In general, there is value in taking the time to be deliberate about communications. Re-read communiques before sending, particularly if they may be perceived as negative or inflammatory to certain parties. The ability to self-edit before sending is a boon to text communication. Vocalized words cannot be unsaid once uttered.

1. Along these lines, we should be clear in proposals, especially when we are making decisions with trade-offs. For example, we shouldn't choose between revenue versus usage or broad versus deep without fuller context. To have buy-in and alignment, we need to get into the specifics. We can't make informed decisions without being clear on the tradeoffs (do A or B) and the proposal (do A but not B). What you should pick depends on the specific situation, and you should aim for agreement on both what you are doing and not doing.

1. Aiming for precision in communication requires you to put yourself in another person's shoes and try to understand their current perspective and worldview. It's important to view text communication not as a way to impose your will, but as a means to listen, understand, and collaborate.

1. This isn't suggesting that your communication should be cold or soulless. In the GitLab thanks Slack channel, for instance, we encourage team members to be specific about what they are thanking someone for, such that you do not need prior context to understand how a value was being lived.

Why text communication can be difficult

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The internet is forever. Words have impact long after they are written, and even when you're communicating internally, the manner in which you speak with one another should be viewed through an external lens. Words have meaning, meanings have effects, and effects have consequences. Those consequences, good or bad, are the lasting impact of the words you choose.

For those who struggle with this, consider what you would type if a journalist, your manager, or a family member were in the room observing the conversation. This tip will not serve all scenarios, but it's worth considering if stakes are high in a conversation.

Below are several reasons why text communication can be difficult.

1. Cultural and communication style differences

- 1. Delay in immediate feedback (due to time zones or other meetings)
- 1. Lack of non-verbals
- 1. Emotional distance
- 1. Tough to fully consider the scope of your audience(s)

Understanding Tone in Text-Based Communication

In February 2022, the Learning and Development team at GitLab hosted Maria Moss for a live speaker series on interpreting tone in text-based communication. Key points addressed in the discussion include:

- 1. Lead conversations with empathy and assume positive intent
- 1. Recognize when text communication isn't working and talk about it
- 1. State your intent clearly and early in a conversation - leave nothing up to interpretation

Watch the recording of this discussion with Maria:

{{< youtube "a9RNgt5u2MQ" >}}

Letting values guide communication

Text communication can be easily derailed, and assumptions can lead to good-mannered communiques being viewed as a slight. A number of GitLab's operating principles are useful to reference if you end up in a scenario where you are unsure of how to communicate effectively and responsibly through text.

- 1. No ego (Don't defend a point to win an argument or double-down on a mistake.)
- 1. Assume positive intent (If a message feels like a slight, assume positive intent while asking for clarification.)
- 1. Get to know each other (Building a rapport enables trust.)
- 1. Say thanks (Taking every opportunity to share praise creates a climate where feedback is viewed as a gift rather than an attack.)
- 1. Kindness (It costs nothing to be kind, even if you do not believe someone deserves it.)
- 1. It's impossible to know everything (You can't know how your words are interpreted without asking.)
- 1. Short toes (GitLab is a place where others can feel comfortable with others contributing to their domains of expertise.)

If, during a text conversation, you feel that someone is not communicating in the spirit of a company's values, respectfully ask if they believe that they are in a 1-1 setting. It's easiest to assume the worst and quietly disengage, but doing so creates several additional problems. One, the person communicating is not given the gift of feedback, so their perspective will not change. Two, the person concerned remains timid about communicating with someone, which can lead to toxicity and dysfunction if unaddressed.

The power of contrition

At the speed of business, it's possible for even the most well-mannered of colleagues to say something regrettable when their heart was typing faster than their brain could regulate. In the event that you think you could have written something better, contrition is advised.

Say sorry is an operating principle at GitLab. It's simple, yet powerful. Saying sorry via Slack or email, or a quick Zoom call if two parties are online at the same time, enables trust to be rebuilt. When using asynchronous collaboration tools such as GitLab Issues and Merge Requests, feel welcome to reply atop your message if you feel that you may have written something offensive. This will send another email notification to those tagged, whereas an edit to your original message will not.

Using GitLab for work-related communication

GitLab is a collaboration tool designed to help people work better together whether they are in the same location or spread across multiple time zones. Originally, GitLab let software developers collaborate on writing code and packaging it up into software applications. Today, GitLab has a wide range of capabilities used by people around the globe in all kinds of companies and roles.

You can learn more at GitLab's remote team solutions page.

Communicating dates and time

You can learn more in GitLab's communication handbook as the Single Source of Truth (SSoT).

Feedback is a gift

Managers should strive to incorporate positive feedback into their day-to-day work. Particularly in an all-remote setting, where people can work for days, weeks, or months without seeing a colleague in person, friendly words go a long way.

It's easy to brush positive feedback aside as nonessential, but that is unwise in a remote setting. If the only feedback a report receives is negative · while hearing nothing when they are exceling · they are likely to view feedback as an attack. Moreover, they're likely to feel unappreciated and misunderstood, and are apt to view critical feedback as something that is being delivered to spite them rather than improve them.

Said another way, putting effort into positive feedback as well as negative feedback creates a climate where the latter is taken seriously. If you are in a situation where you need to deliver critical feedback, consider also offering up what a person is doing well. This creates an element of trust, that you are viewing things in totality and recognize that people are not their work.

Feedback is a mechanism to become more understanding and more compassionate. In remote settings where you're working with colleagues from around the globe, feedback enables you to squash misconceptions and become a more understanding human. Though challenging, you should assume positive intent when receiving feedback. If it feels like an attack, ask for clarification.

The goal is to create a two-way street of communication, so that all parties are heard, and work is put in by all sides to ensure that points are understood. It's also important to think through your responses to feedback. You can't choose how you are spoken to, but you can control how you respond.

If your default reaction to feedback is to become combative, consider acknowledging feedback

and respectfully asking for time to process. Then, schedule a follow-up conversation once you've had time to process it rationally and not just emotionally. This prevents you from feeling compelled to reply in haste.

It's about your impact, not your intention

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We judge ourselves by our intentions, but people judge us by our actions.

In an all-remote setting, it's important to have a healthy amount of perspective on words that you type. Ask for clarification, and ask if your communication could be delivered in a different or more effective way.

For managers of multiple people, you may find that one report prefers a certain delivery while another has a different idea of what is ideal. There are multiple ways to deliver a message. Similarly, there are multiple ways to interpret a message. It's worth being proactive to ensure that your intentions are delivered.

When communicating, it's your responsibility to own how something impacted someone, regardless of how you intended it. If you're surprised by how a given communicate impacts someone, ask for clarity without being combative. These moments are ideal for learning more about yourself, and how you can tweak your approach to communicating via text to be more considerate.

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Communicating effectively and responsibly through text

Complete all knowledge assessments in the Remote Work Foundation certification to receive the Remote Foundations Badge in GitLab Learn. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

Contribute your lessons

Specific examples of using text effectively are ideal for showing new hires how to learn this skill. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

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SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/evaluate.md

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On this page, we're detailing how to evaluate a remote job.

Not every remote job is created equal

{{< youtube "4bO-wxLQtJQ" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (GitLab) and Rodolphe (Remotive) discuss several remote work topics: favorite things about remote work, how to find/start/thrive in your first remote role, and the impact of the growing remote work community.

While job sites and common conversation can lump each remote role into a single category, it's important to realize that not every remote role is created equal. Just as colocated roles need to be evaluated in totality, those seeking to transition into a remote role for the first time should ask certain questions during the interview or evaluation phase.

There are various stages of remote work, which can be easily pictured as a sliding scale. From no remote to hybrid-remote to all-remote, and all points in between, a remote worker's experience in each setting will likely vary. Below, we're highlighting key topics to cover when seeking an understanding of how you'll be treated in a full-time remote role. Additional questions should be considered depending on your specific scenario and familiarity with the hiring company.

While there are a growing number of freelance gigs which can be completed remotely, this article is centered around full-time remote careers.

Where can I find remote jobs?

We've curated a list of companies and job boards to help in your search for remote jobs. We've also included a list of qualities to look for as you're evaluating potential employers.

What factors should be considered when evaluating a remote job?

When considering employment, it's essential to evaluate the totality of the job. While things like compensation, safety/security, management style, day-to-day tasks, and benefits are paramount for some, others see flexibility, autonomy, and the ability to travel and regularly relocate as a higher priority.

It's wise to rank your personal priorities in order of importance as you consider a remote job. Depending on your preferences and work style, all-remote may or may not suit you well.

How to research a company before accepting a job offer

Company values serve as the north star guiding every business decision by people you cannot physically see and shaping how colleagues treat one another, especially in a remote setting. Every company has a unique culture and values. Remote interviewees should research a company's values and ask questions about them during the interview process.

How do remote companies evaluate prospective employees?

Remote organizations search for people who place a high degree of value on autonomy, flexibility, empathy, and mobility.

Because of the self-directed nature of remote work, employers look for people capable of:

- being a manager of one
- working asynchronously
- communicating through text
- setting up an ideal workspace
- eliminating distractions for optimal efficiency

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Other remote-work questions to consider

Q: Where does leadership work?

When evaluating a remote role, it's critical to understand where leadership works on a day-to-day basis. In an all-remote company, each team member · including the executive team · is remote. This creates a culture of trust and transparency, and it sends a clear message that no one will be treated as an outsider within the organization based on their geographic location.

In companies where the leadership team is colocated, but most (if not all) of the company is remote, consider asking how this impacts the dissemination of information. Remote forces companies to do things they ought to be doing earlier and better, including documenting culture and process. With a colocated leadership team, a company runs the risk of bypassing diligent documentation in favor of an in-person sync where discussion notes and outcomes are not documented and shared.

Q: Are hybrid calls utilized or tolerated?

In hybrid-remote companies, where certain team members are colocated and others are remote, consider asking how meetings and calls are handled. Hybrid calls are often allowed or encouraged, though they offer a suboptimal experience for remote attendees. Ideally, each call participant will have their own equipment (camera, headset, and screen), even if multiple members are colocated.

This ensures that each team member is treated equally, and removes typical boardroom issues such as difficulty seeing body language through a wide-angle camera and being interrupted or booted from a room.

Q: Is there flexibility with working hours and days?

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Flex-work and workplace flexibility have grown in popularity, but it's important to ask for specific examples of how this actually works within a company you are considering joining.

Do only senior leaders have complete flexibility to schedule their working hours and days around their lives? Is workplace flexibility truly embraced and supported throughout the organization? Does the company empower team members to be a manager of one, valuing outputs

rather than inputs such as hours worked?

When life happens and you need to restructure your day on the fly, is this openly encouraged and supported or quietly frowned upon?

Answers to these questions are critical in understanding the true level of autonomy you'll be given to add value in a given company.

Q: Do teams default to asynchronous work, or adhere to select time zones?

It's important to understand how teams work within an all-remote company. In organizations where asynchronous communication is the default, it's likely that team members are diligent about documentation, resist the urge to schedule meetings, and are sensitive to atypical working hours/arrangements.

Certain companies prefer to have everyone contributing between certain times, creating additional boundaries on those who live too far east/west from the proverbial company epicenter and for some who regularly change locations and time zones.

Q: How is information disseminated?

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Documentation is important in all companies, and the answer to this question should shed light on how much a company values it. Ideally, a company will have a handbook or similar where processes and culture are documented first, and then shared out (via email, Slack, etc.).

Q: Approximately how many times did you reference the company handbook last month, and propose changes to it?

Similar to the above, this question allows you to talk specifics on how processes and solutions are iterated upon, and who is empowered to contribute. (Hat tip to Wes Winham Winler for the question.)

Q: Are cloud collaboration tools the default?

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Consider asking if notes are captured using an online collaborative suite (Office 365, Google G Suite, etc.). This is a more transparent, efficient, and collaborative approach compared to emailing documents back and forth, which creates versioning headaches.

Q: How is informal communication encouraged and enabled?

Remote companies must be intentional about informal communication. When some or all team members are not able to foster relationships in person, a company must take deliberate steps. Consider asking for specific examples of how a company has created an atmosphere where team members are encouraged to connect as humans, not just colleagues.

Q: What percentage of your team was hired without an in-person meeting?

Breaking the habit of requiring an in-person touch point for situations of significance (e.g. hiring someone, bringing on a new agency partner, etc.) is tough. While there is nothing inherently wrong with having an in-person touch point along the hiring process if it's convenient, you'll learn a lot about an organization's faith in virtual conversations by asking this question.

Q: What percentage of your team's social/team-building activities last quarter were remote (versus in-person)?

In-person interactions are important in remote organizations. Asking this question provides valuable insight into a company's strategy for building bonds through planned in-person activities, as well as how equipped they are to facilitate team-building through remote interactions.

Q: What percentage of your group meetings last week resulted in a written artifact?

This question dives into a couple of areas. It provides an opportunity to understand if a company truly embraces asynchronous communication, and it exposes their true view and use of meetings.

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Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

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SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/events.md

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Remote work conferences and summits

Remote-work events can be a great place to meet others who have experience and connections in the space. They are particularly valuable for those who are seeking a new role with an all-remote or remote-first company.

What is a remote work conference?

>A conference is a company or industry-specific meeting where people gather to discuss topics related to their field.

>

A remote work conference happens online and is usually somewhat formal. Speakers have been chosen ahead of time to deliver presentations or participate in panel discussions, such as the "REMOTE by GitLab" and other global conferences featuring GitLab speakers.

REMOTE by GitLab

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> "REMOTE by GitLab" is a premier event exploring the future of workplace design, strategy, and culture. During this half-day symposium on June 29, 2021, attendees learned how to create and sustain scalable remote practices within their teams and organizations. REMOTE by GitLab featured sessions from top remote leaders, detailing how remote work is transforming lives, companies, and communities. As one of the largest all-remote companies, GitLab brought together the workplace design community to inspire the future of business and culture in the post-office world.

>

> Couldn't join us live? Watch the recordings on demand.

What is a remote work summit?

>A summit is typically a formal, standalone event with a narrowly defined focus.

>

Remote summits may be by invitation only and encourage idea-sharing, discussion, or invite a specialized group of people to focus on solving a specific problem. Take a look at the summits below.

Running Remote

{{< youtube "7DYy029Ebg" >}}

> Running Remote is carefully curated to teach you next-level, actionable strategies, and tactics you can utilize the very next day to manage and grow your distributed team. Their mission is to provide the education and tools that founders and professionals need to succeed in the future of work. This is a gathering of leaders who will share everything they've learned running a remote first organisation.

The Remote Work Summit

{{< youtube "3iFCbBT7Xt4" >}}

> The Remote Work Summit is an initiative to bring together 24+ industry leaders from Fortune 500 companies, startups and agencies to share their secrets of building effective remote teams,

organizations & careers. You can watch the recorded sessions from the third edition of the event, which took place in April 2020.

Flex Summit

{{< youtube "H0KovHDg268" >}}

> Flex Summit 2021 is a week-long virtual summit devoted to the future of flexible work. In 2019, Fuze hosted the first-ever Flex Summit, an in-person destination summit for leaders engaging in the future of flexible work. This year, Flex Summit Week 2021 is re-imagining the traditional virtual event structure · releasing content daily. The week takes place from Monday, June 14 · Friday, June 18, 2021.

RemoteCon

> RemoteCon is a remote conference on remote work. It took place April 7, 2020 on Zoom. RemoteCon is organized by Marcel Salathé and a group of volunteers at EPFL who believe that remote is not only changing how we work, but also how society organizes itself. Getting remote work right is thus one of the biggest challenges of the 21st century. It's time to talk about it.

What is the difference between a remote work conference and a remote work summit?

Conferences are typically open to a broad audience, whereas summits are sometimes invitation-only for a specifically targeted group. Conferences are more about sharing information, whereas summits solve problems. Both are excellent places to gather cutting-edge information about the remote-working space and network with others in the industry.

Experiencing a remote work event

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<div data-bbox="114 618 916 702" data-label="Text">
<p>Before the pandemic, most conferences and summits required your physical presence for you to receive maximum impact. Networking, learning, and discussions were face-to-face in a shared physical space. If you couldn't make it, you missed out. Select in-person conferences recorded snippets of panels and keynote speeches for viewing after the conference ended, but did not offer a way for dialogue to continue.</p>
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<div data-bbox="114 718 886 801" data-label="Text">
<p>As events and conferences pivoted to virtual platforms in 2020-2021, organizers learned to connect and engage with attendees in creative new ways. While many conferences will likely reincorporate in-person elements in the future, the tools and expertise gained through more than a year of exclusively virtual events should enable conferences to be more inclusive and accessible.</p>
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<div data-bbox="114 817 896 868" data-label="Text">
<p>Given that remote work summits are engineered to be open to anyone, anywhere in the world, virtual access is a vital part of ensuring that a global community can engage with content, speakers, panelists, and keynotes.</p>
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<div data-bbox="120 884 307 900" data-label="Section-Header">
<h2>Benefits for attendees</h2>
</div>

Remote work events welcome anyone interested in the future of workplace design. The beauty of remote work events is that everyone is welcome, even those who may still be skeptical of or learning about remote work.

All-remote and remote-first workflows change rapidly. Technology, tools, mobile network infrastructure, internet ubiquity, and a cultural understanding of virtual communication all contribute to making remote work increasingly feasible. Those who have a negative view of remote work, but are curious to see how the space is evolving, stand to gain much from attending remote work conferences and summits.

The power of networking

Networking takes additional consideration in the all-remote space, given that people congregate in the same physical space less often. This creates opportunity for conferences and summits to bring remote workers from all over the globe together, serving as a catalyst for collaboration, communication, and inspiration.

Those seeking a remote role can learn about emerging and established firms in the all-remote and remote-first space, channeling their energy to apply at companies that they are aligned with.

If you're a founder or hiring manager, these events offer a platform to promote your company to potential candidates who understand and appreciate the benefits and drawbacks of all-remote.

Renewed purpose and mission

As remote work becomes more popular, a number of conferences and summits are emerging to serve a few key purposes.

1. Educate the world on the power and efficiency of working remotely, including those who have not yet embraced remote work.
1. Bring remote workers and companies together to fuel collaboration and share learnings.
1. Provide a platform for experts to share knowledge with the broader remote work community.
1. Create a tighter, more unified network of all-remote and remote-first advocates to evangelize for the creation of more remote roles.

Benefits for speakers and presenters

Speakers and presenters can present from anywhere. They may be on a stage with others in a shared physical space, or they may be presenting from anywhere in the world via computer and webcam. By removing the need to travel and carve out large chunks of one's schedule, the virtual nature of a remote work conference creates a significant opportunity for summit hosts to capture a more diverse array of speakers.

Asynchronous engagement

A major boon of remote work summits is the ability to engage asynchronously. Even if you're unavailable for the entirety of the live event, all-remote and remote-first events are typically structured to be experienced at your leisure. For example, the prior year of The Remote Future Summit can still be experienced now, as all sessions were captured and archived

for future viewing.

Building a community

The remote community welcomes outreach from others working remotely. If you view a session that contributed to your knowledge and understanding of an issue, it's not out of line to reach out to the speaker(s) who presented via email, Twitter, etc. and begin a dialog · even months after the live event concludes.

GitLab remote events

To find remote-focused events that GitLab is hosting or participating in, please check the main GitLab Events page.

Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/getting-started.md

On this page, we're detailing considerations and tips for getting started in a new remote role.

What exactly is a remote job?

In an all-remote organization, each individual is empowered to work and live where they are most fulfilled. A remote job allows you to work from wherever you're most comfortable. That could be a coffee shop, your basement office, a coworking space, or even a different place every month!

During the interview phase, get an understanding of how the company defines remote work

Different companies will have different approaches to remote work. Make sure you understand what your work environment will be like, and whether it matches your own working style.

Remote work is not for everyone. To be a great remote worker, make sure you understand this GitLab operating principle on being a manager of one.

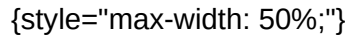
Another element to flesh out during an interview is remote communication. GitLab is an asynchronous company. Much of what we do is communicated through text. For people used to working in-office and default to verbal communication, it may take some time to transition to communicating information via text.

Prepare for a different type of onboarding

Being stressed about learning a new job is a reality for many people. Remote onboarding for new GitLab team-members may be new as they join our all-remote culture. Prepare yourself to be flexible, open, and ready to listen, learn, research, try new things, and get comfortable with videos and video calls for your onboarding process.

How do I prepare for the first day of remote work?

For those who have not worked in a remote organization before, you may want help thinking through an ideal workspace and need a few tips and tricks for informal communication. Make sure your technology and internet are all working and connected and be ready to introduce yourself, take notes, and ask questions.

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Don't be afraid to ask for help

Whether you're new to working remotely or have been doing it for a long time, don't be afraid to ask co-workers for advice. It may be helpful to request a mentor to help you acclimate faster.

If you're interested in finding remote communities to learn from, try one of these:

- 1. LinkedIn Digital Nomads and Remote Workers group
- 1. Reddit Remote Work
- 1. WeWorkRemotely community

Take time to internalize values

{{< youtube "7kMQj4O4ZGU" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Sid (co-founder) and Darren (Head of Remote) discuss the importance of values at GitLab.

Absorbing a company culture in a colocated setting occurs over time, as one witnesses behaviors that are supported, praised, and discouraged. A benefit to working in an all-remote setting is that culture is (ideally) documented.

As you settle into a new role, ensure that you devote time to reading and internalizing company values. While this may feel like a skippable activity, understanding the values early on enables you to have a strong foundation on which to build. Every decision you make in your role should be guided by values. If you have questions about how values are lived, take time during onboarding to consult with others.

At GitLab, one's Onboarding Buddy is there to answer these questions and provide guidance. There is also a values Slack channel for related discussions. Whenever you see a value being lived, we encourage the use of a values emoji reaction to reinforce values being used day-to-day.

Adjusting to a self-service mindset

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GitLab's 100% remote culture and our workplace methodologies are highly unique. You should not

expect to transfer the norms of colocated corporations into a work from anywhere scenario. Those who thrive at GitLab take the opportunity to drop prior workplace baggage at the door, embrace a liberating and empowering set of values, and give themselves permission to truly operate differently.

So differently, in fact, that many of GitLab's most effective processes would be discouraged or forbidden in conventional corporations. It's not a trap. It's the future of work.

Explore the resources in our all-remote handbook section, as well as our collection of relevant blog posts, for a deeper understanding of life at GitLab.

Focus your workspace

If you've managed to be productive despite operating within a conventional open office floor plan, you'll likely be thrilled with your productivity level as a remote team member.

However, engineering an optimal workspace may not come naturally · particularly if you've worked in environments which were defined prior to you joining.

For new remote workers, it's important to think about where you prefer to work on a daily basis. Optimize this for focus. Consider spaces in your home, coworking venue, etc. where you will be largely free from distraction. Given that most offices are riddled with distractions, the ability to design a space that dodges them is a boon for remote workers.

The more focused you are due to your surroundings, the more quickly you can accomplish your duties and move on to important non-work activities.

Pay close attention to ambient sounds, visual distractions, and areas of high traffic. Aim to dedicate a space where only work occurs, enabling you to focus specifically on work while there and healthily disconnect when you exit.

Establish routine with family and friends

{{< youtube "BC7Prkm3v3g" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, two GitLab colleagues discuss the benefits of living in a lower cost-of-living environment near friends, family, and community.

When you physically leave a home to go to work, it signals to friends and family that you are not easily reachable, and that you are focused on work-related tasks. In a work from anywhere scenario, you're able to remain at home all day should you so choose.

For families who are not used to this, boundaries can be difficult to establish and maintain. When an employee is visibly at home, it may signal to other family members that they are accessible.

Consider having an open, honest conversation with family members about your working hours. Explain that while you are indeed home, you should be considered unreachable unless there's a significant level of need that would roughly align with justifying an office interruption in a colocated setting.

This tends to be particularly vital to discuss with children, who may struggle to understand why a working parent is in the home but are unable or unwilling to engage with them for certain parts of the day.

By explaining that a working parent is able to spend more time engaging immediately prior to and after work due to dropping the commute, it helps frame the new scenario in a way that spotlights the benefits to a child. To take this a step further, consider arranging your work schedule to allow for a midday activity with a child. By engaging in this manner, and explaining that such a luxury would have been impossible in a colocated setting, it can help reinforce the benefits of remote work.

Consider visual availability indicators that will allow friends and family to easily know whether or not you're willing to be contacted during working hours.

Experiment with work environments

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While working from home is an ideal scenario for many, you may find that you're happier, more fulfilled, and more productive elsewhere. If you feel burdened or socially drained while working from home, consider a coworking space or an outdoor area.

Preferences vary from person to person, and even from season to season. For example, you may find that working while road-tripping in an RV is exactly the kind of environment to maximize your personal and professional happiness.

Or, you may find that working with other nomads in a foreign location provides added clarity and creativity.

People adopt a remote lifestyle for many reasons. It's important to consider unique work environments if you're new to a remote role. If you've been forced into an office for your entire career, you may not instinctively know which work environment is best for you. By experimenting and asking for advice from others who have worked remotely before, you may discover a side of yourself that's finally able to flourish due to newfound flexibility.

At GitLab, team members are allowed to expense costs associated with coworking spaces or external offices, as we recognize that working out of one's home is not always ideal or desired. If you're new to a remote role, ask your manager if external office space is reimbursable.

Prioritize ergonomics

Whether it's in your home office, at a coffee shop, a coworking space, or elsewhere, consider ergonomics in every instance.

Pay close attention to seating and posture, as well as repetitive stress on arms and wrists. It's worth investing in equipment designed to help you work healthier. Cutting corners in this area now can lead to chronic pains in the future.

At GitLab, team members are allowed to spend company money as they would their own. If you're new to a remote role, ask your manager if ergonomic equipment is reimbursable.

Procure the right equipment for working remotely

Working remotely enables you to work from all types of environments. Those new to remote working are unlikely to have equipment optimized for that flexibility.

Items such as standing/treadmill desks, standing mats, external keyboard/mice, high-definition webcams, webcam lighting, noise-cancelling headphones, a dedicated microphone, a laptop riser, and ergonomic cases/backpacks should be considered depending on your work scenario.

Do remote employers provide work equipment?

Not all remote employers provide work equipment. This is an important question to ask during your interview process. However, at GitLab, team members are allowed to spend company money as they would their own, with guidance provided for various types of equipment.

How to connect with people when starting a remote job

While you will naturally connect with people during your onboarding, you will also need to be intentional about relationship-building via informal communication with your co-workers.

Below are a number of intentional facets of GitLab's culture, created to foster connections.

1. Social call: A series of optional calls once a month on a Tuesday, to which everyone in the organization is invited. We have no set agenda, but items can be added to the linked document. This is just a time set aside for everyone to openly talk where everyone is a moderator.
1. Contribute Unconference: An in-person, week-long event where we bring the entire company together in one location to get to know each other better.
1. Social hours: Informal social calls organized within our immediate teams to get to know each other on a more personal level.
1. Local meetups: Co-located team members are encouraged to organize their own meetups, whether it's a co-working space or getting dinner together.
1. Slack: We use Slack channels for informal communications throughout the company, whether it's a team-specific channel or a channel dedicated to sharing vacation photos with other team members.
1. Zoom calls: Not only do we get to know our coworkers better by seeing them in real time during video calls, we also get to know their pets and families too. This visual engagement helps us relate to each other on a more personal level, so when we meet in person, we already know each other. In fact, when our team members meet face-to-face for the first time, the most surprising factor is usually each person's height.
1. Gaming: GitLab has a gaming Slack channel where fans of video games and digital board games can connect. Coordinating shared gaming sessions is a great way to informally connect with team members and collaborate toward goals outside of work.
1. Music making: GitLab's musicmaking Slack channel is a place where artists can come together and collaborate synchronously or asynchronously to make music together. Several GitLab team members came together to create All I Want This Quarter Is You (GitLab), a musical masterpiece on the GitLab Unfiltered YouTube channel.

How to be successful in your first week of remote working

Familiarize yourself with the company's technology & tools

Spend time getting to know GitLab's publicly viewable handbook, which captures everything you need to know about the company.

Technology is ever-changing. Which is one reason why GitLab's onboarding process includes exercises in self-service via an onboarding issue with multiple tasks broken down into small, digestible chunks. Each issue guides new hires to complete certain tasks on certain days, being a manager of one · an operating principle of Efficiency · applies from the very beginning.

Develop a schedule that you can initially follow

Create a routine, then tweak it to find what works best for you. Start with a consistent workday routine, or determine when you have waves of peak productivity and design your work day and routine around them.

Begin to create connections with co-workers

If you worked at an office before, you might miss interacting with your coworkers at lunch or in the office hallways. In a remote environment, you need to be more intentional about connecting with coworkers. Make time for coffee chats, reach out to teammates, and share details of your life to help people get to know you.

Set up work-life boundaries

Be intentional about planning your time off.

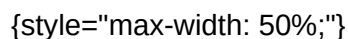
When you're not working, disconnect by turning off Slack and closing down your email client. At GitLab, this only works if all team members abide by the communication guidelines. It also helps to enable the "working hours" feature on your calendar so that team members in other time zones know when to schedule meetings.

Get accustomed to the communication preferences of your co-workers

GitLab encourages non-work related communication (talking about private life on a team call) for relationship building. Take advantage of group video calls for bonding, one-on-one video calls between people (as part of onboarding), and be sure to attend periodic summits with the whole company to get to know each other in an informal setting.

Ask your co-workers what their preferred methods of communication are; write them down; and be sure to use their preferred method/s.

Bolster your internet connection, and consider redundancy

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It's important to remember that remote workers are responsible for their own connectivity. This may require you to invest in a more substantial home internet connection. It's worth consider

redundancy in this department as well. For example, upgrading your smartphone plan to support tethering or investing in a dedicated mobile hotspot or MiFi. This ensures that you have a fallback connection in place should your primary connection fail.

Secondary connections are particularly important when multiple family members work from home. For example, if one member is uploading a large file, that may impact the audiovisual quality of another member's video call. A secondary connection allows each working member to operate on their own without impacting the bandwidth of the other.

Manage isolation and mental health

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For those accustomed to social interactions within a colocated work setting, it can be jarring to move into a remote environment where you primarily work alone.

It's important to pay close attention to your mental health and emotional health as you transition to a remote role. If you sense a void from missing out on face-to-face interaction, act deliberately and early.

Here are a few suggestions to avoid isolation.

1. Schedule breaks in your day to interact with friends or family in the home, or nearby in your community.
1. Experiment with working in a shared setting (e.g. a local coworking venue, WiFi Tribe, etc.).
1. Leverage video calls whenever practical, both at work and outside of work.
1. Engage with colleagues on non-work topics, via Slack, ad hoc video calls, or other communication tools.
1. Prioritize work events where travel and physical interaction is involved (e.g. company summits, meetups, events, conferences, etc.).

For GitLab team members, be sure to join the [mentalhealthaware](#) Slack channel and read our [guide on combating burnout, isolation, and anxiety in the remote workplace](#).

Be intentional about informal communication

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Lean in when it comes to informal communication. While this requires the use of an unusual muscle · particularly for those who have not worked in a remote setting before · it's important to form and foster relationships.

Making social connections with coworkers is vital to building trust within your organization. One must be intentional about designing informal communication when it cannot happen

organically in an office.

If your new remote role does not specify informal communication options available to you, consider reading GitLab's list and implementing at your company.

Imagine what's possible with no commute

{{< youtube "gyDGeibTfdk" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, two GitLab colleagues discuss the benefits of all-remote. In particular, the ability to travel on a continual basis while working and visiting colleagues, friends, and family.

Perhaps the most inspiring and thrilling aspect of embracing a remote role is the sheer potential of it. The possibilities are near limitless when you're empowered to live and work where you are most fulfilled.

While traveling the globe or working from a beachside cafe may not appeal to everyone, remote work enables a dramatically different lifestyle for all. By removing one's commute and ditching the requirement to be seen in a physical office, you're able to structure your work around your life as opposed to the other way around.

This is a profound shift, and it may not be entirely obvious how to maximize one's new reality.

Consider starting a document listing things that working within a colocated environment prevents you from doing. Items such as dropping children off for school, participating in midday community service functions, visiting friends and family outside of peak holiday seasons, learning a new language by living in a foreign locale, relocating to care for an ill relative, moving to a more satisfying environment, working in a more comfortable wardrobe, etc.

By taking a look at what you've been missing, you're able to more easily assemble a plan for embracing such things in a remote setting.

Consider asking yourself what you'll do with the time you save by losing the commute. Perhaps you'll be inspired to embrace a daily fitness routine, cook at home, or spend additional time with friends, family, and community. There's nothing wrong with reclaiming that time and using it to bolster your overall wellness, from improving